F1

FOCUSED STUDY SPREAD

Numbers

Census, camp, and the two petitions

SOURCE MARGIN

NUM 1–36

MT · LXX

MILGROM, NUMBERS (JPS)

LEVINE, NUMBERS (AB)

Return of the Household

REGISTRY FORM H-1

FILED UNDER THE DOMINION ACT · ONE COPY TO THE TEMPLE, ONE TO THE CROWN

HOUSEHOLD OF	_____
AUTHORITY LINE	*the adult male on record*
COUNTED	*men of age, by house*
REGISTERED APART	*Vowed, Temple staff*
LEFT UNCOUNTED	_____
DEPENDENTS	*entered under the authority line*
DESIGNATION	*to be assigned*

Numbers 1 counts men twenty and older, by ancestral house, who can go to war. **POSSIBLE**
The Registry's household return is the same form with a newer letterhead.

COUNTED

FOCUSED STUDY F1 · ✣

Numbers

A book that opens by counting everyone and closes by deciding who inherits. Between the two it records every complaint the wilderness produced, and treats some of them as rebellion and others as law.

WHY THIS IS A FOCUSED STUDY

Numbers gives the Empire its census, its camp and its line between an approved petition and a criminal one. Three things, so it gets ten pages and not seventeen.

CAN BE PROMOTED

If the Trials lean harder on census and registration than expected, this spread becomes a full dossier. The review box is on the close-the-spread page.

What it is

NAME	English *Numbers*, from the Greek *Arithmoi* and the Latin *Numeri*, named for its two censuses. The Hebrew name, *Bemidbar*, means "in the wilderness," from the book's opening words. The two traditions name different books.
PLACE	Fourth book of the Torah. It carries the story from Sinai to the edge of the land and holds the material Leviticus doesn't narrate.
STRUCTURE	Three movements by place. Chapters 1–10 at Sinai: counting, camp and departure. Chapters 11–21 in the wilderness: complaint, scouts, condemnation, rebellion, death. Chapters 22–36 on the plains of Moab: Balaam, the second census and the inheritance rulings.
GENRES INSIDE	Census register, itinerary, legal ruling, narrative, poetry, oracle, and a folk tale about a talking donkey. The registers and the stories weren't written to be read the same way.
THE FIGURES	603,550 fighting men in chapter 1 and 601,730 in chapter 26, which implies a population in the millions. **CONTESTED** Whether the numbers are literal. Proposals include a different meaning for the word translated "thousand," schematic totals and later expansion. None is settled.
NEIGHBORS	Ancient Near Eastern military rosters, land grants and boundary records cover the same administrative ground. Reading Numbers beside them shows it as a governing document as well as a story.

WHAT THE BOOK IS ABOUT, IF IT'S ABOUT ONE THING

INTERPRETATION Who is on the list, and what being on the list gets you. Nearly the whole generation counted in chapter 1 is dead by chapter 26, Caleb and Joshua excepted, and most of the generation that inherits wasn't counted the first time.

WHAT I ALREADY THINK THIS BOOK IS, BEFORE READING IT AGAIN

NUM 1.1

NUM 1–10

NUM 11–21

NUM 22–36

MILGROM, NUMBERS

TKC: DOM

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT I ALREADY THINK THIS BOOK IS, BEFORE READING IT AGAIN

Counting as governance

NUM 1
NUM 2
NUM 3–4
NUM 26
LEVINE, NUMBERS
TKC: DOM

The census counts men twenty years old and up who can go to war, by ancestral house. What it produces is a military muster, an ancestral register and a marching order. Women and children aren't counted. The Levites are registered separately, by a different rule and from a different age. **INFERENCE** A register like this also served taxation, labor drafts and conscription, judging by ancient Near Eastern practice. Numbers itself doesn't say so.

	FIRST CENSUS · CH. 1	SECOND CENSUS · CH. 26
WHERE	The wilderness of Sinai, the second year out	The plains of Moab, a generation later
PURPOSE	Muster for war and order the camp	Divide the land by the size of each tribe
TOTAL	603,550	601,730, almost the same after forty years of death
WHO SURVIVES	The generation that left Egypt	Of that generation, only Caleb and Joshua
WHAT IT PROVES	The people are numerous, organized and ready	**INTERPRETATION** The promise outlived the people who first received it

THE CAMP · CH. 2

Twelve tribes in fixed positions on four sides, three to a side, each under its own standard, with the Levites in an inner ring around the tabernacle and Moses and Aaron at the entrance. A tribe's place in the camp is assigned, recorded and set up the same way at every stop.

WHAT THE EMPIRE TAKES

POSSIBLE The whole apparatus with the theology intact: a register that decides who exists, a place assigned by house, and the claim that the arrangement is holy. Household registration (**FR 32**) is Numbers 2 on Imperial letterhead.

WHO IS COUNTED IN THE EMPIRE, WHO IS ONLY REGISTERED, AND WHO IS NEITHER

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHO IS COUNTED IN THE EMPIRE, WHO IS ONLY REGISTERED, AND WHO IS NEITHER

Two speak. One is marked.

Numbers 12 is usually summarized as Miriam challenging Moses. The Hebrew is more exact than that. Verse 1 uses a feminine singular verb for the speaking while naming Miriam and Aaron together, and verse 2 shifts to plural speech. Aaron is present in both verses. The punishment falls on one of them.

WHO SPEAKS	Miriam and Aaron, both named, against Moses. The grammar puts Miriam first without removing Aaron.
THE STATED OCCASION	The Cushite woman Moses had married. The text raises her and never comes back to her.
THE REAL CLAIM	Prophetic authority: has the LORD spoken only through Moses? The marriage is the occasion, and the claim is about jurisdiction.
THE REPLY	A divine speech that separates how God speaks to prophets in general from how God speaks to Moses. It ranks the office and doesn't deny that others prophesy.
THE PUNISHMENT	Miriam's skin is struck with a scaling disease, described as white. Aaron gets no visible punishment. He pleads for her, Moses intercedes, and she's shut outside the camp seven days.
THE DETAIL NOBODY QUOTES	The people don't move on until she's brought back. The whole march waits for the woman it just expelled.

WHAT THE TEXT DOESN'T SAY

It never explains why only Miriam is marked, and it doesn't rank their guilt. Interpreters have supplied reasons for centuries. Some point to the feminine verb in verse 1. Some argue that a high priest with a skin disease would have shut down the sanctuary. INTERPRETATION The grammar is real, and what it's supposed to justify is never stated. The silence is part of the text.

WHERE I'VE SEEN THIS ASYMMETRY: IN THE TEXT, IN CHURCHES, IN THE EMPIRE, IN MY OWN CHAPTERS

NUM 12.1

NUM 12.2–8

NUM 12.9–16

EXOD 15 (MIRIAM THE PROPHET)

TRIBLE, "BRINGING MIRIAM OUT"

TKC: MIRIAM

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHERE I'VE SEEN THIS ASYMMETRY: IN THE TEXT, IN CHURCHES, IN THE EMPIRE, IN MY OWN CHAPTERS

Korah and the daughters

NUM 16

NUM 17

NUM 27.1–11

NUM 36

JOSH 17.3–6

TKC: TR · DOM

These aren't the same act with different results. They differ in who brings them, what's asked, how and where it's asked, and how the narrator frames them. Side by side, the question isn't whether Numbers approves of dissent. It's which petitions this authority is able to hear.

	KORAH · CH. 16	ZELOPHEHAD'S DAUGHTERS · CH. 27
WHO	Korah the Levite, Dathan, Abiram and On of Reuben, and 250 men of standing	Mahlah, Noah, Hoglah, Milcah and Tirzah, five sisters, each named
ASKS FOR	Priestly access: the holiness of the whole congregation against Aaron's sole office	An inheritance in their father's name, since he died without sons
METHOD	An assembly against Moses and Aaron, then a censer test of authority	They stand before Moses, Eleazar, the chiefs and the whole congregation at the tent of meeting and state their case
FRAMING	The narrator calls it rebellion before the reader can weigh it	The narrator reports the petition without a verdict and lets the ruling answer it
MOSES	Falls on his face, then proposes the test	Takes the case to the LORD instead of deciding it himself
OUTCOME	The ground opens and fire consumes the 250. Chapter 17 secures Aaron's office again with a budding staff.	Granted, and made a general law of inheritance
AFTERWARD	Korah's line survives as singers, the sons of Korah, named in the Psalms headings	Chapter 36 narrows the win: they must marry within their father's tribe so the land stays put. Granted, then fenced.

THE QUESTION TO CARRY, NOT THE CONCLUSION TO PRINT

INTERPRETATION A petition that works through the system's own procedure, asks for a defined thing and leaves the office alone can be granted and written into law. One that contests who holds the office is answered with the ground.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH PETITION IS EDEN BRINGING, AND DOES SHE KNOW WHICH ONE IT LOOKS LIKE TO THE TEMPLE?

Build the procedure

WRITING

NUM 27

NUM 36

TKC: TR · DOM

The Empire has an approved petition and a criminal one, and Numbers gives you the template for both. Draft the Empire's version here. This page is source material for the Trials, not a study exercise.

1 · WHAT A LAWFUL PETITION LOOKS LIKE IN THE EMPIRE: WHO MAY BRING IT, WHERE, AND IN WHOSE PRESENCE

2 · THE LINE A PETITION CROSSES TO BECOME SEDITION, AND WHO DECIDES IT'S BEEN CROSSED

3 · THE CHAPTER 36 MOVE: A CONCESSION THAT'S LATER FENCED. WHERE DOES THE EMPIRE DO THIS?

4 · A SCENE WHERE A WOMAN WINS SOMETHING REAL AND THE WIN IS NARROWED AT ONCE

NUM 11

NUM 13–14

NUM 20

NUM 21.4–9

2 KGS 18.4

NUM 22–24

NUM 27.12–23

Forty years of consequence

THE SCOUTS AND THE CONDEMNED GENERATION · 13–14

Twelve are sent to see the land. All twelve agree it's fertile, ten judge the inhabitants unbeatable, and Caleb and Joshua dissent. The people side with the ten, and the generation is told it won't enter: forty years, a year for each day of scouting. **INTERPRETATION** Whether there's a line between describing an obstacle honestly and making it grounds for refusal is a question the text raises and doesn't settle.

COMPLAINT AS A GENRE · 11, 20, 21

Food, water, leadership, and Egypt remembered as better than freedom. The complaints repeat by design. Moses complains too, at length, and isn't punished for it, which is worth holding beside Miriam's page.

THE BRONZE SERPENT · 21:4–9

Serpents are sent, and Moses is told to make a bronze one. Anyone who looks at it lives. Centuries later Hezekiah destroys it because people had started making offerings to it (2 Kgs 18:4). A commanded object becomes one that has to be destroyed.

WHAT THE WILDERNESS LOOKS LIKE IN THE EMPIRE'S TEACHING

Seers and successors

NUM 22–24

NUM 31.16

2 PET 2.15

NUM 27.12–23

TKC: TR

BALAAM AND THE DONKEY · 22–24

A foreign seer is hired by Balak of Moab to curse Israel. His donkey sees the divine messenger before he does, and speaks. He then blesses Israel four times. Later texts, in Numbers 31 and in the New Testament, treat Balaam as a villain, so the Balaam of chapters 22–24 and the Balaam of later memory behave very differently.

LEADERSHIP PASSED ON · 27:12–23

Joshua is commissioned in public, by the laying on of hands before Eleazar and the congregation, while Moses is still alive. Succession here is a witnessed ceremony and not an inheritance.

WHAT THE EMPIRE HARVESTS FROM THE MIDDLE

POSSIBLE A theology of delay. If the wilderness is punishment for an earlier generation's failure of nerve, any hardship now can be explained as inherited discipline, and endurance becomes the whole of obedience. The Trials' Endurance phase (**TR**) is this doctrine with a broadcast schedule.

WHICH OF THESE FIVE I ACTUALLY NEED, AND FOR WHICH CHAPTER

WRITING

SPREAD CLOSE

QUEUE: F1

What I take out of Numbers

THE ONE THING THIS BOOK CHANGED ABOUT HOW I SEE THE EMPIRE

WHAT I STILL DON'T UNDERSTAND. CARRY IT TO THE RESEARCH LIST.

A LINE, AN IMAGE OR A PROCEDURE I'M TAKING STRAIGHT INTO THE MANUSCRIPT

PROMOTION REVIEW *log only, no promotion is made here*

Numbers is a focused study, and it can be promoted to a full dossier. Promote it if two or more of these turn out true: the census becomes structural to the Trials and not background, Miriam's punishment becomes a load-bearing precedent for how the Empire treats women who speak, the petition contrast drives a real plot decision, or these writing pages fill up and run out of room.

DECISION | DATE | PAGES NEEDED

NOTES

OPEN NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DIDN'T FINISH

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

F4

FOCUSED STUDY SPREAD

1 and 2 Chronicles

The same history told again, for a different congregation

SOURCE MARGIN

1–2 CHR

MT · LXX

JAPHET, I & II CHRONICLES (OTL)

KNOPPERS, 1 CHRONICLES (AB)

The Register of Households

COVENANT RECORD, VOL. I

ENTERED BY THE TEMPLE CLERK · CERTIFIED TRUE TO THE OLDER ROLLS

LINE OF	_____
DESCENDED FROM	*entered as far back as the rolls allow*
STANDING	*priestly · landed · resident · none on record*
WOMEN NAMED	_____ *(enter where the line runs through her)*
CERTIFIED BY	_____

First Chronicles 1–9 runs from Adam to the settlers of Jerusalem, name by name. ***POSSIBLE*** *Dominion's household register (**FR 32**) is the same instrument, kept for the opposite reason.*

ENTERED

FOCUSED STUDY F4 · ✣

1 and 2 Chronicles

The same centuries, told again by someone with a temple to justify and a congregation to hold together. What it leaves out is famous. What it adds is more interesting.

WHY THIS IS A FOCUSED STUDY

Chronicles isn't a new story. It's a second telling. Nine pages are enough to hold what changed, why a community after the exile would want it changed, and what an empire learns from a sanctioned retelling.

READ IT AGAINST SAMUEL–KINGS

This spread only works in comparison. Keep a Samuel–Kings text open beside it, or the differences stay invisible.

What it is

NAME	The Hebrew title, *Divrei Hayyamim*, means "the events of the days," an annals title. The Greek tradition called it *Paraleipomena*, "the things left out," which is a judgment about the book wearing the clothes of a label.
WHERE IT SITS	In the Jewish ordering it's the last book of the whole Bible, and it ends with a Persian king telling the exiles to go up. In the Christian ordering it sits after Kings, in the middle. Same text, two different final words.
WHEN AND BY WHOM	Anonymous, and generally placed in the Persian period, after the return. Whether the same hand wrote Ezra–Nehemiah was long assumed and is now widely questioned. Treat "the Chronicler" as a label for an unknown writer and not as an identified person.
STRUCTURE	Nine chapters of genealogy. David, at length. Solomon and the temple. The kings of Judah only, down to the exile, closing with the decree of Cyrus. The northern kingdom mostly isn't its subject.
ITS SOURCES	It draws on Samuel and Kings, often nearly word for word, and also cites records the reader can't check. It's a book openly built out of other books, which makes it the Bible's clearest case of a tradition editing itself.
ITS PURPOSE	Theological, liturgical and genealogical, written for a community after the exile that needed to know it was continuous with what came before. INTERPRETATION Calling it "the authorized version" or "state-sponsored scripture" is an argument about that purpose. Use those phrases as arguments you're making and never as facts you're reporting.

WHAT THE BOOK IS ACTUALLY DOING

INTERPRETATION Proving that a small, occupied province with a rebuilt temple is the same people as the kingdom in the old stories. Continuity is the argument, the genealogies are the evidence and the temple is the proof.

1 CHR 1–9

2 CHR 36.22–23

JAPHET, I & II CHRONICLES

WILLIAMSON, ISRAEL IN CHRONICLES

1–2 KGS (COMPARE)

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT I ASSUMED CHRONICLES WAS, BEFORE READING IT NEXT TO KINGS

Subtraction and addition

2 SAM 11–12

1 CHR 3.5

2 SAM 24 · 1 CHR 21

2 CHR 29–31

2 CHR 33.10–20

KNOPPERS, 1 CHRONICLES

The omissions are the famous part and the least interesting way to read the book. Chronicles also adds a great deal Samuel–Kings doesn't have, and keeps damaging material it could easily have dropped. Study the pattern and not only the gaps.

MATERIAL	WHAT CHRONICLES DOES WITH IT
BATHSHEBA AND URIAH	The story isn't retold. Bathsheba isn't erased. She appears in David's genealogy as the mother of Solomon and three other sons, under the name Bath-shua (1 Chr 3.5). The dynastic record keeps her, and the scandal is absent.
AMNON, TAMAR, ABSALOM	The household violence and the revolt aren't retold. The reign comes through war, worship and preparation for the temple instead.
DAVID'S CENSUS	Kept, with the plague and the deaths. Where Samuel says the LORD incited David, Chronicles says an adversary did (1 Chr 21.1). The sin stays and the attribution moves. **INTERPRETATION** A book doing pure whitewash wouldn't have kept the chapter.
LEVITES, SINGERS, MUSICIANS	Added, extensively. Named guilds, rotas, instruments and duties Samuel–Kings barely mentions. For what a working sanctuary staff looked like, this is the source.
HEZEKIAH'S PASSOVER	Added. A mass reform and festival, with invitations sent north to people outside Judah's jurisdiction. A reunification liturgy (2 Chr 30).
MANASSEH	Added. Kings gives Judah's worst king no redemption. Chronicles has him taken to Babylon with hooks, pray and be restored (2 Chr 33.11–13). **INTERPRETATION** The most theologically loaded addition in the book, since it says no reign is beyond repentance.

HOW TO READ THE OMISSIONS HONESTLY

A retelling that assumes its reader knows the older account isn't the same as one that hides it, and Chronicles points readers to other records. **CONTESTED** "Cover-up" is one available reading. Another is a history written for worship more than for judgment. Hold both, and say which one you're using.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THE OMISSION I FIND HARDEST TO READ CHARITABLY, AND WHY

One reign, two tellings

WORKSHEET

2 SAM · 1 CHR

1–2 KGS · 2 CHR

Pick one king. Read his reign in Samuel or Kings, then in Chronicles, and log what moved.

	SAMUEL–KINGS	CHRONICLES
King and chapters		
How the reign opens		
What's kept word for word		
What's missing		
What's added		
Who gets the blame		
How it ends		

WHAT THE SECOND TELLING PROTECTS, AND WHO IT PROTECTS IT FOR

1 CHR 1–2

1 CHR 2.34–35

1 CHR 4.9–10

1 CHR 4.18

1 CHR 7.18

1 CHR 7.24

1 CHR 9.1–34

KNOPPERS, 1 CHRONICLES

TKC: DOM

The register as an argument

INTERPRETATION The nine chapters most readers skip are the book's foundation. A community whose records were broken by deportation is establishing, name by name, who belongs, who serves and who holds land. It's the same instrument as Numbers 1, used to prove a people didn't end, where Numbers used it to muster an army.

FROM ADAM FORWARD

The list begins with the first human and narrows to the nations, Israel, the tribes, Judah, David, the priests and Levites, and the settlers of Jerusalem. A funnel. The whole world is in the frame at verse one so the small province at the end can be its point.

THE WOMEN IN THE LISTS

Named women turn up more often than these chapters' reputation suggests. Sheerah builds Lower and Upper Beth-horon and Uzzen-sheerah (7.24). Sheshan has no sons and gives his daughter to Jarha, his Egyptian servant, and the line runs through them (2.34–35). The text records the marriage and the descent and doesn't say she inherits. Hammolecheth is named among Manasseh's descendants (7.18). Bithiah, a daughter of Pharaoh, is recorded as a wife without comment (4.18). Jabez's mother names him (4.9). Nobody preaches these chapters, so nobody notices. Mine them.

WHAT A GENEALOGY DOES POLITICALLY

INTERPRETATION It assigns priestly eligibility, land claims and standing. It also excludes, since to be missing from the register is to have no documented claim. The list is a comfort and a boundary at once.

GAPS AND VARIANTS

Names, spellings and lines differ from parallels elsewhere, and some segments are incomplete. Ancient genealogies were claims about relationship, arranged to make a point, more than birth certificates.

THE DIRECT LINE TO DOMINION

POSSIBLE Household registration, lineage verification and the Covenant record are this technology. Chronicles keeps the register to gather in a scattered people. Dominion keeps it to rank a gathered one.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHO IN THE CAST ISN'T ON A REGISTER, AND WHAT IT COSTS THEM

WRITING

2 CHR 36

TKC: DOM · TL

Write the Empire's second telling

Dominion has an official history of the Fall. Chronicles shows how a sanctioned retelling actually behaves. It keeps more than you expect, adds liturgy, moves blame without deleting the event, and ends on the note it wants remembered. Build yours on that model and not on crude deletion.

1 · WHAT THE EMPIRE'S HISTORY OF THE FALL KEEPS, EVEN THOUGH IT'S DAMAGING

2 · WHERE IT MOVES THE BLAME WITHOUT REMOVING THE EVENT

3 · THE LITURGY IT ADDS. WHAT THE OFFICIAL VERSION HAS THAT THE OLD ONE DIDN'T

4 · THE LAST SENTENCE OF THE OFFICIAL HISTORY, DRAFTED WORD FOR WORD

What I take out of Chronicles

WRITING

SPREAD CLOSE

QUEUE: F4

THE ONE DIFFERENCE FROM SAMUEL–KINGS THAT CHANGED MY READING

A NAME FROM THE GENEALOGIES I WANT TO USE, AND WHERE

WHAT I STILL DON'T UNDERSTAND. CARRY IT TO THE RESEARCH LIST.

PROMOTION REVIEW *log only, no promotion is made here*

Chronicles is a focused study. Log a promotion if the Empire's official history becomes a plot object more than background, or if the register material outgrows this spread. **OPEN QUESTION** A combined study with Ezra and Nehemiah, titled Restoration, Record and Exclusion, has been floated. The decision belongs in the backlog.

LOGGED | DATE | REASON

NOTES

OPEN NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DIDN'T FINISH

F5

FOCUSED STUDY SPREAD

Ezra

A restoration paid for by an empire, and the assembly that sent families away

SOURCE MARGIN

EZRA 1–10

MT · LXX

WILLIAMSON, EZRA, NEHEMIAH (WBC)

BLENKINSOPP, EZRA–NEHEMIAH (OTL)

Decree of Return

ISSUED UNDER THE ROYAL SEAL

TO THE TREASURERS BEYOND THE RIVER · LET IT BE DONE WITH DILIGENCE

THE HOUSE TO BE REBUILT	*at the place where sacrifices are offered*
ITS COST	*to be paid from the royal treasury*
THE VESSELS	*returned, each counted out by number*
WHO MAY GO	*any of his people who are willing*
WHO MAY STOP IT	*no one, on pain of the decree*

Ezra 6.3–12 quotes the decree as it was found again in the archive at Ecbatana. **POSSIBLE** *Every licensed church in the Empire hangs a framed copy of something like it.*

FOUND IN THE ARCHIVE

FOCUSED STUDY F5 · ✣

Ezra

A homecoming paid for by the empire that allowed it, and a covenant renewal that ends with women and children sent out of the community. Both halves are the same book.

WHY THIS IS A FOCUSED STUDY

Ten chapters, two movements and an ending that doesn't resolve. Nine pages hold the imperial mechanics and the marriage crisis without turning either into a verdict.

CONTENT NOTE

Page 3 deals with the expulsion of wives and children from a community, and with the dispute over what to call it. The note is repeated on the page itself.

WHAT IT IS

ONE BOOK OR TWO	Ezra and Nehemiah were handed down together in the Hebrew tradition and separated later, and they're commonly studied as one body of work. Whether they're one composition, and by whose hand, is still disputed. This companion gives them separate spreads and treats the shared reading as a tradition of study more than a settled fact.
STRUCTURE	Chapters 1–6, the first returns and the rebuilding of the temple, decades before Ezra appears. Chapters 7–10, Ezra arrives with a royal commission and the community confronts intermarriage. The long gap between the halves isn't narrated.
TWO LANGUAGES	Part of the book is in Aramaic, the administrative language of the Persian empire, and that section is mostly correspondence: petitions, archive searches and decrees. The book quotes paperwork. **CONTESTED** Whether the documents are authentic, edited or composed.
WHO PAYS	The empire. Cyrus authorizes the return and releases the temple vessels. Artaxerxes later sends Ezra with silver, gold, supplies, tax exemptions for temple personnel and authority to appoint judges. The restoration is a Persian-sanctioned project from the first verse.
EZRA HIMSELF	A priest by descent and a scribe of the law, arriving from Babylon with a commission. He's a religious authority whose standing is issued by a foreign king. Hold both halves of that at once.
HOW IT ENDS	With a list of names of men who had married foreign women, and a final verse whose Hebrew is hard to read. There's no resolution scene, no aftermath and no account of what happened to the women and children. The book stops.

> **WHAT THE BOOK IS ACTUALLY ABOUT**
>
> **INTERPRETATION** Survival of a small community under imperial patronage, and the boundary it draws to get there. It's a book about what a threatened people is willing to do to stay identifiable.

EZRA 1.1–4

EZRA 4.8–6.18 (ARAMAIC)

EZRA 7.11–26

EZRA 10.44

BLENKINSOPP, EZRA–NEHEMIAH

TKC: DOM

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT I EXPECTED A "RETURN FROM EXILE" BOOK TO FEEL LIKE

A TEMPLE BUILT BY PERMISSION

Nothing in the first six chapters happens without imperial authorization, and the book doesn't treat that as a compromise. Persia is the instrument of the return. For a novelist building an empire that licenses religion, this is the primary text.

THE DECREE AND THE VESSELS	Cyrus issues the authorization, and the temple vessels Babylon took are counted back out of an imperial treasury. Looted property comes back as policy. Restoration arrives as an inventory.
THE LIST OF WHO RETURNED	A register by household and town, with a group who couldn't document their descent and were kept out of priestly service until a ruling could be had (2.59–63). The register decides standing on arrival. Put it beside Chronicles and Numbers, the same instrument a third time doing a third job.
TWO SOUNDS AT THE FOUNDATION	When the foundation is laid, the young shout for joy and the old who remembered the first house weep, and the text says the noise couldn't be told apart (3.12–13). One of the most useful sentences in the Bible for writing a restoration scene.
OPPOSITION AS PAPERWORK	The work is stopped by a letter and not an army. Neighboring officials write to the king calling the rebuilding a security risk, an archive is searched, and construction halts until a later search finds the original decree and reverses the ruling. Bureaucratic obstruction, on both sides, in writing.
WHO IS TURNED AWAY EARLY	People already living in the land offer to help build and are refused, with no reason given beyond the decree (4.1–3). The boundary that dominates chapters 9–10 is drawn here first, over labor.

WHAT DOMINION FUNDS, AND WHAT IT REQUIRES IN RETURN FOR FUNDING IT

EZRA 1

EZRA 2.59–63

EZRA 3.10–13

EZRA 4.1–5

EZRA 4.6–24

EZRA 6.1–18

WILLIAMSON, EZRA, NEHEMIAH

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT DOMINION FUNDS, AND WHAT IT REQUIRES IN RETURN FOR FUNDING IT

CONTENT NOTE The expulsion of women and their children from a community by collective decision, and the ethical dispute over how to describe it. You can work this page later, or not at all, and the spread still functions.

THE BOUNDARY, AND WHO PAID FOR IT

WHAT HAPPENS	Officials report that men of the community, priests and Levites among them, have married women of the surrounding peoples. Ezra tears his clothes and prays a long confession in the first person plural. A proposal is made to send away the wives and the children born to them. An assembly agrees, a commission examines cases household by household, and a list of names is recorded.
THE CHILDREN	The children are named in the proposal alongside the wives. **INTERPRETATION** Here a boundary about identity becomes a decision about particular children.
THE SILENCES	No woman speaks, and none is named. Where they went, who took them in, whether they had families to return to and what happened to the children aren't recorded. A few men object (10.15), and the text doesn't explain why.
WHAT "FOREIGN" MEANS	**CONTESTED** Some read an ethnic boundary, some a religious one, and some a fight over land and inheritance between returnees and people who never left. Others read the list of peoples as old legal language more than a description of the actual women. The stakes are high, and the text doesn't settle it.
SCALE	The recorded list is a little over a hundred men. **CONTESTED** Whether the action was carried out fully, partly, or is an idealized account of a policy. The parallel scene in Nehemiah 13 suggests it didn't stay settled.

ON THE PHRASE THIS COMPANION WON'T USE

INTERPRETATION "Ethnic cleansing with a liturgy" carries a modern legal category into a text whose scale, mechanism and definition of the group are all disputed. It also flattens a real, serious ethical problem into a slogan, which makes it easier to dismiss. The ethical dispute stays on this page in full. A forceful wording of the objection doesn't get treated as accurate for being forceful.

EZRA 9

EZRA 10

NEH 13.23–30

DEUT 7.1–4

SOUTHWOOD, ETHNICITY AND THE MIXED MARRIAGE CRISIS

ESKENAZI, IN AN AGE OF PROSE

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WRITE ONE OF THE WOMEN. NAME HER. GIVE HER THE SENTENCE THE TEXT DIDN'T.

Write the Empire's file

Ezra is a book that quotes its own correspondence. Draft the Empire's documents on the same model, a letter of complaint, a search of the archive and a decree that settles it.

1 · THE LETTER: WHO WRITES TO THE CAPITAL TO STOP A REBUILDING, AND WHAT DANGER THEY NAME

2 · THE ARCHIVE SEARCH: WHAT'S FOUND, AND WHO GETS TO READ IT

3 · THE DECREE: ITS OPENING WORDS, ITS FUNDING LINE AND ITS PENALTY CLAUSE

WRITING

EZRA 4.11–16

EZRA 5.7–17

EZRA 7.12–26

TKC: DOM

WRITING

SPREAD CLOSE

QUEUE: F5

What I take out of Ezra

A RELIGIOUS AUTHORITY WHOSE POWER IS ISSUED BY THE EMPIRE. WHO IS THIS IN MY CAST?

A BOUNDARY DRAWN TO PROTECT A COMMUNITY THAT COSTS ITS MOST VULNERABLE PEOPLE

WHAT I STILL DON'T UNDERSTAND. CARRY IT TO THE RESEARCH LIST.

PROMOTION REVIEW *log only, no promotion is made here*

Ezra is a focused study. Log a promotion if the marriage crisis becomes a governing precedent in Dominion law more than a parallel, or if the material on imperial patronage carries the Sanctum's origin story. **OPEN QUESTION** The combined Restoration, Record and Exclusion study stays in the backlog.

LOGGED | DATE | REASON

NOTES

OPEN NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DIDN'T FINISH

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

F6

FOCUSED STUDY SPREAD

Nehemiah

A wall, a register, a debt crisis, and a governor who worked for the king

SOURCE MARGIN

NEH 1–13

MT · LXX

WILLIAMSON, EZRA, NEHEMIAH (WBC)

ESKENAZI, IN AN AGE OF PROSE

Order of the Gates

POSTED AT EVERY ENTRANCE

BY THE GOVERNOR OF THE PROVINCE · TO THE GATEKEEPERS, SINGERS AND LEVITES

GATES OPEN	*not until the sun is hot*
GATES SHUT	*while the guards are still standing*
GUARDS	*residents, each opposite his own house*
SABBATH	*gates shut from dark, no load to enter*
MERCHANTS OUTSIDE THE WALL	*will be dealt with*

Nehemiah 7.3 and 13.19–21, nearly word for word. ***POSSIBLE*** *Every checkpoint in the Empire runs on this order.*

BY ORDER

FOCUSED STUDY F6 · ✣

Nehemiah

A memoir by a man who held a post at the imperial court, went home with an escort, rebuilt the city's defenses in fifty-two days, made his own class give back what it had taken, and enforced a boundary by force.

WHY THIS IS A FOCUSED STUDY

Nehemiah is among the most administratively detailed books in the Old Testament, and the closest to how Dominion actually runs. Nine pages hold the mechanics: employment, security, registers, debt and enforcement.

FIRST PERSON

Much of the book is Nehemiah's own account of himself, including prayers asking to be remembered for it. Read it as testimony from an interested party.

What it is

HIS JOB	Cupbearer to the Persian king, a trusted office at court that carries personal access to the monarch. He then serves as governor of the province. His authority to act in Jerusalem is delegated imperial authority.
FORM	Largely a first-person memoir, with lists, letters, a covenant document and a long public reading set into it. Scholars commonly identify a "Nehemiah memoir" running through the book with other material inserted. CONTESTED Where the seams fall.
STRUCTURE	Chapters 1–7, the commission, the night inspection, the building, the opposition, the debt crisis and a register. Chapters 8–10, the public reading of the law, confession and a signed covenant. Chapters 11–13, settlement lists, dedication and a final enforcement campaign.
THE WALL	Rebuilt in fifty-two days by crews assigned to the stretch nearest their own houses, with families, guilds and perfumers named. Half the workforce stood armed while the other half built. Defense and construction as one operation.
HOW IT ENDS	With a return visit and a purge in place of a dedication: a temple chamber cleared, Sabbath trade shut down by locking the gates, and confrontations over marriages that include beatings and cursing. The book closes with Nehemiah asking to be remembered for good.

WHAT THE BOOK IS ACTUALLY ABOUT

INTERPRETATION Building an institution and then policing it. The construction is the first half and the enforcement is the second, and the book doesn't present them as different projects.

WHAT I WAS TAUGHT ABOUT NEHEMIAH, AND WHAT THAT TEACHING LEFT OUT

NEH 1.11

NEH 2.1–9

NEH 3

NEH 4.15–23

NEH 6.15

NEH 13

WILLIAMSON, EZRA, NEHEMIAH

TKC: DOM

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT I WAS TAUGHT ABOUT NEHEMIAH, AND WHAT THAT TEACHING LEFT OUT

SECURITY AS A THEOLOGY

NEH 2.7–9

NEH 2.11–16

NEH 3.12

NEH 4

NEH 6.1–14

NEH 7.1–5

INTERPRETATION The wall is the book's controlling image, and it's a real defensive perimeter with gates, guards, hours and a list of who may open them. Everything the second half does about identity is already implied in the first half's masonry.

THE PAPERWORK HE ASKS FOR	Letters of safe passage to the provincial governors and a requisition to the keeper of the king's forest for timber. An escort of officers and cavalry. He arrives as an official with a materials order.
THE NIGHT INSPECTION	He surveys the ruins at night, telling no one what he intends, and presents the plan as a decision already made. Information control comes before construction.
WHO BUILDS	Priests, goldsmiths, perfumers, district rulers, people from outlying towns, and one official who builds with his daughters (3.12). Chapter 3 is a labor roster, one of the clearest places in the Bible to see a whole community's trades assigned to public works.
OPPOSITION, RUMOR AND A SETUP	Ridicule, threats of attack, repeated invitations to a meeting outside the city, an open letter claiming he means to make himself king, and a hired prophet urging him to hide in the temple. He refuses all of it. The clearest sequence in scripture on how a construction project becomes a political accusation.
THE GATES AND THE REGISTER	Once the wall stands, he sets the gate hours and appoints guards, and in the same breath convenes an enrollment by genealogy. Wall and register arrive together.

DOMINION'S PERIMETER. WHERE IT IS, WHO GUARDS IT AND WHEN IT OPENS

NEH 5.1–5

NEH 5.6–13

NEH 5.14–19

NEH 10.31

LEV 25 (COMPARE)

DEUT 15 (COMPARE)

TKC: DOM · MEN

Chapter five

In the middle of the building project the account breaks off for a debt crisis. The workers are hungry and their children are being taken. The text doesn't say construction stopped. It reports a crisis serious enough to interrupt the narrative. It's the most economically explicit chapter in the historical books, and one of the least preached.

THE OUTCRY	A great outcry from the people "and their wives" (5.1). Three groups speak: those with no land, those mortgaging land for grain, and those who've borrowed against fields and vineyards to pay the king's tax.
THE CHILDREN	They say their sons and daughters are being forced into slavery for debt, some daughters already, and they're powerless because their fields now belong to others. Debt bondage inside the community, in the same weeks as the sacred building project.
THE CREDITORS	The nobles and officials, the same class doing the building and signing the covenant. The crisis is internal, and no foreign oppressor is needed.
THE REMEDY	Nehemiah confronts them in public, calls it wrong, orders fields, houses and interest returned and makes them swear to it before the priests. He also gives up the governor's food allowance and says he fed a large table at his own expense. Reform by a member of the creditor class, on the creditor class.
THE LIMIT	INTERPRETATION Chapter 5 is immediate relief backed by an oath and personal authority. The covenant in chapter 10 makes a seventh-year release a standing obligation. Neither changes the lending system or the imperial tax that drove the borrowing, and the text doesn't say how long either was enforced.

THE TAX IS THE ENGINE

INTERPRETATION The people say outright that they borrowed to pay the king's tax. The debt crisis is downstream of imperial extraction, and the reform touches the local creditor and leaves the empire alone, since the empire isn't available to be reformed. For a Dominion economy, that's the whole shape of it.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

HOW A DOMINION HOUSEHOLD LOSES A DAUGHTER TO DEBT. WRITE THE MECHANISM.

NEH 8

NEH 9

NEH 10.28–39

NEH 13.4–14

NEH 13.15–22

NEH 13.23–31

FISHBANE, BIBLICAL INTERPRETATION IN ANCIENT ISRAEL

Signed, then policed

The middle of the book is a public reading and a signed agreement. The end is what happens when the agreement isn't kept. Read them together or the ending looks arbitrary.

THE PUBLIC READING	A morning-long reading in an open square before men, women and all who could understand, with Levites giving the sense so the people understood (8.8). The people weep, and they're told to feast and send portions to those with nothing. **CONTESTED** Whether "giving the sense" includes translation into Aramaic is a common reading and a debated one.
THE SIGNED COVENANT	A sealed document with named signatories committing to specific obligations: no intermarriage, no Sabbath trade, a seventh-year release, a temple tax, wood offerings and firstfruits. A funding and compliance schedule with a religious preamble.
THE TEMPLE CHAMBER	He comes back to find a temple room given to an outsider and the Levites unpaid and gone back to their fields. He throws the household goods out and restores the payments. The reform failed the moment its enforcer left.
THE SABBATH SHUTDOWN	Winepresses working, grain hauled and foreign traders selling on the Sabbath. He orders the gates shut before dark and posts his own men, and when merchants camp outside he threatens to lay hands on them. Sabbath observance enforced as a border operation.
THE MARRIAGE CONFRONTATION	He reports contending with the men, cursing them, beating some and pulling out their hair, and driving out a priest's son who'd married into the family of a rival governor. He reports it approvingly, as zeal. Unlike Ezra 10 there's no assembly, commission or list, only an official's personal violence recorded in the first person. **INTERPRETATION** The marriages also tie Jerusalem's priestly families to neighboring provincial power.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

A REFORMER WHOSE REFORM ONLY HOLDS WHILE HE'S IN THE ROOM. WHO IS THAT HERE?

WRITING

SPREAD
CLOSE

QUEUE: F6

What I take out of Nehemiah

THE PERIMETER AND THE REGISTER ARRIVE TOGETHER. WHERE DOES DOMINION DO THIS?

LEADERSHIP AIMED AT ITS OWN CLASS. WHO IN MY CAST REFORMS THE PEOPLE THEY BELONG TO?

A SCENE WHERE OBSERVANCE IS ENFORCED BY LOCKING A GATE

WHAT I STILL DON'T UNDERSTAND. CARRY IT TO THE RESEARCH LIST.

PROMOTION REVIEW *log only, no promotion is made here*

Nehemiah is a focused study. Log a promotion if the debt and bondage material becomes the spine of Dominion's economy more than one mechanism among several, or if chapter 5 outgrows its page here. **OPEN QUESTION** The combined Restoration, Record and Exclusion study stays in the backlog.

LOGGED | DATE | REASON

NOTES

OPEN NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DIDN'T FINISH

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH

F2

FOCUSED STUDY SPREAD

Ecclesiastes

Hevel, the court passages, and fatalism the Empire can use

SOURCE MARGIN

ECCL 1–12

MT · LXX

FOX, QOHELET AND HIS CONTRADICTIONS

SEOW, ECCLESIASTES (AB)

Ecclesiastes 10.20

Do not curse the king, even in your thoughts,
or curse the rich, even in your bedroom.

For a bird of the air may carry your voice, or
some winged creature tell the matter.

✣

A surveillance proverb in the canon, about two and a half thousand years before the Broadcast.

FOCUSED STUDY F2 · ✣

ECCLESIASTES

A book inside the canon that says the system can't be figured out, the record won't be kept, and you should eat your dinner anyway. Dangerous material for an empire that needs meaning handed down from above.

WHY THIS IS A FOCUSED STUDY

Twelve short chapters and one sustained argument. What you need is hevel handled correctly and the court passages pulled out, and eight pages do that.

READ IT WHOLE FIRST

It's one of the few biblical books short enough to read in an hour, and it doesn't survive being read in fragments. Read it before working these pages.

What it is

NAME	The Hebrew is *Qohelet*, from a root meaning to assemble or convene, roughly "the Assembler," someone who addresses a gathering. The Greek title translates it. A role, more than a personal name.
THE SPEAKER	Introduced as "son of David, king in Jerusalem." Solomon is never named. **INTERPRETATION** Best read as a literary persona, a royal voice adopted so the experiment of chapters 1–2 can run with unlimited means. Modern scholarship generally dates the book's Hebrew well after Solomon, commonly to the Persian or Hellenistic period. If you treat the speaker as a historical king, say you're doing it.
TWO VOICES	First person for most of twelve chapters, then a third-person voice at the end describing Qohelet from outside and commending him, with qualifications. Many read the epilogue as an editorial frame. **CONTESTED** Whether it endorses the book, tames it or corrects it.
GENRE	Wisdom literature turned adversarial. It uses the forms of instruction to question instruction. Royal testament, observation report, proverb collection and poem sit side by side.
STRUCTURE	No tidy outline, and the proposals disagree. What's visible: the royal experiment (1–2), the poem on times (3), a run of observations on injustice, labor, wealth and death (4–10), advice for the young and the closing poem on age (11–12), and the epilogue.
NEIGHBORS	Egyptian and Mesopotamian pessimism literature and royal testaments cover similar ground. Job is the closer neighbor in the canon. Both refuse the standard account of reward and punishment, by different routes.

> **WHAT THE BOOK IS ACTUALLY ARGUING**
>
> **INTERPRETATION** It argues that outcomes don't track merit, that nobody can see the whole pattern, and that this is a reason to take what's in front of you seriously and keep going. The book refuses to lie, and it stops short of despair.

ECCL 1.1

ECCL 1.12

ECCL 12.9–14

FOX, QOHELET

JOB (COMPARE)

TKC: DOM

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT I WAS TAUGHT THIS BOOK MEANT, AND WHO TAUGHT ME

Hevel

ECCL 1.2

ECCL 12.8

BDB · HALOT, HEVEL

GEN 4 (ABEL)

VULGATE, VANITAS

KJV 1611

One Hebrew word appears dozens of times across twelve chapters and frames the whole book, first verse and last. Its concrete sense is vapor, breath or mist, something real that won't stay in your hand. Every English rendering is an interpretation, and each one produces a different book.

RENDERING	THE BOOK IT PRODUCES
"VANITY"	The traditional English, reaching us through the Latin *vanitas*. In modern English it suggests conceit, which isn't the sense, and it makes the book sound like a sermon against pride.
"MEANINGLESS"	The strongest and the most misleading. It turns an observation about impermanence into a verdict on existence, and the book keeps recommending things, which a meaningless world wouldn't allow.
"ABSURD"	Stresses the gap between what should follow and what does. Useful, and it carries modern philosophical baggage.
"FUTILE"	Keeps the effort and denies it a result. It fits the labor passages and fits the enjoyment passages badly.
"VAPOR" OR "BREATH"	Keeps the image and lets the reader do the work. It also connects to the name Abel in Genesis 4, the same consonants, a resonance the Hebrew reader hears and the English reader never does.

WHAT THE BOOK ALSO SAYS. DON'T CUT THIS HALF.

Eat, drink and find good in your labor. Enjoy your bread and your work. Do it with the person you love. These recommendations come back again and again, and they're the counterweight to every "vapor" verdict. A summary that keeps only the bleak half isn't summarizing this book.

QUOTATION WARNING

"Eat your bread, love someone, the day is short" is a paraphrase of the enjoyment passages and not a verse. "Nobody will remember you" compresses several passages on memory and drops the ones about a good name. Never print either as a quotation.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH RENDERING I'M USING, AND WHY THAT ONE

Written by someone who's been near power

ECCL 4.1

ECCL 5.8–9

ECCL 8.2–4

ECCL 10.16–20

SEOW, ECCLESIASTES

TKC: DOM

The book's political passages are the ones nobody puts on a coffee mug. They read like advice from someone who has watched administration from inside and doesn't expect it to improve.

OPPRESSION WITH NO COMFORTER · 4.1	He looks at the oppressed and notes twice that they have no one to comfort them, and that power is on the other side. No explanation is offered for why God allows it. The observation is left standing.
THE CHAIN OF OFFICIALS · 5.8–9	Don't be astonished at oppression and the denial of justice in a province, followed by a clause about one official watching over another. These are among the hardest verses in the book, and translations split sharply on who's watching whom and whether verse 9 defends or indicts the king. **CONTESTED** A tiered bureaucracy where each level answers upward is one strong, common reading, and the Hebrew allows others.
OBEY, BECAUSE HE CAN · 8.2–4	Keep the king's command. Don't stand in a bad cause before him. His word is powerful, and no one asks him what he's doing. **INTERPRETATION** Counsel for survival more than an endorsement, and Dominion will print it as an endorsement.
THE BIRDS WILL CARRY IT · 10.20	Don't curse the king even in your thoughts, or the rich in your bedroom, since a bird of the air may carry the word. A surveillance proverb in the canon. Take this one whole.
A CHILD FOR A KING · 10.16–17	Woe to the land whose king is a servant, or a child, and whose princes feast in the morning. Happy the land whose king is nobly born and whose princes eat at the proper time. **INTERPRETATION** Class assumptions fully intact. The book criticizes governance without asking who's entitled to govern.

WHICH OF THESE COULD BE READ ALOUD IN THE SANCTUM WITHOUT ANYONE FLINCHING, AND WHICH COULDN'T

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH OF THESE COULD BE READ ALOUD IN THE SANCTUM WITHOUT ANYONE FLINCHING, AND WHICH COULDN'T

The most useful book in the Empire's hands

ECCL 3.1–8

ECCL 9.11

ECCL 8.2–4

ECCL 12.13–14

TKC: DOM

INTERPRETATION Fatalism is an excellent instrument of government. If nothing can be changed, nothing needs changing, and the person who says so sounds wise instead of compliant. Ecclesiastes can be made to say this. It doesn't say it, but the raw material is all there, and the Sanctum wouldn't have to add a word.

THE PASSAGE	THE USE, AND WHAT IT LEAVES OUT
A TIME FOR EVERYTHING · 3.1–8	**POSSIBLE** Read as divine scheduling. Your suffering has its season, so endure it on time. What it leaves out is that the poem lists killing, tearing down and hating as appointed too, which makes it a description of the whole range of human doing more than a comfort.
TIME AND CHANCE · 9.11	**POSSIBLE** Read as "outcomes aren't yours to control, so accept your placement." What it leaves out is that the verse directly denies that the swift and the strong reliably win, which undercuts every ranked competition the Empire runs.
OBEY THE KING · 8.2–4	**POSSIBLE** Read as a standing command. What it leaves out is the reason given, which is that he has the power, and nothing about his having the right.
THE EPILOGUE · 12.13–14	**POSSIBLE** The Sanctum's favorite verse in the book, since it's the one sentence that sounds like an instruction. Quoting the last two verses and skipping twelve chapters is the cleanest example of the Empire's reading method.

> **THE HARDER QUESTION FOR TKC**
>
> Fatalism also protects people. A woman who believes the outcome was never hers to decide can survive a verdict that would otherwise destroy her. The Empire teaches this doctrine cynically, and some of the characters will need it sincerely. Leave the tension unresolved and write it.

WHO IN MY CAST BELIEVES THIS SINCERELY, AND WHO TEACHES IT KNOWING BETTER

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHO IN MY CAST BELIEVES THIS SINCERELY, AND WHO TEACHES IT KNOWING BETTER

What I take out of Ecclesiastes

WRITING

ECCL 12.9–14

SPREAD CLOSE

QUEUE: F2

THE EPILOGUE. DOES IT ENDORSE THE BOOK, TAME IT OR ARGUE WITH IT? MY READING

A SANCTUM TEACHING BUILT ON THIS BOOK. DRAFT THE ACTUAL WORDING

A CHARACTER WHO HAS REACHED THIS BOOK'S CONCLUSION HONESTLY

WHAT I STILL DON'T UNDERSTAND. CARRY IT TO THE RESEARCH LIST.

PROMOTION REVIEW *log only, no promotion is made here*

Ecclesiastes is a focused study. Log a promotion if the Empire's use of the book becomes a plot thread of its own more than atmosphere. If the Sanctum starts teaching it on the page, the epilogue will need its own spread.

LOGGED | DATE | REASON

NOTES

OPEN NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DIDN'T FINISH

F3

FOCUSED STUDY SPREAD

EZEKIEL

Exile, the departing glory, and chapters 16 and 23

SOURCE MARGIN

EZEK 1–48

MT · LXX

GREENBERG, EZEKIEL (AB)

PEARCE & WUNSCH, DOCUMENTS OF JUDEAN EXILES

Route of Departure

AS SEEN BY THE PRIEST, SON OF BUZI

LOGGED FROM A RIVER IN BABYLONIA · THE SIXTH YEAR OF THE KING'S EXILE

STAGE ONE	*from above the cherub to the threshold of the house · 9.3*
STAGE TWO	*from the threshold to the east gate · 10.18–19*
STAGE THREE	*out of the city, to the mountain on the east · 11.23*
RETURN	*by way of the east gate, into a measured house · 43.1–5*
INTERVAL	*thirty-two chapters*

The glory of God leaves the temple in stages, recorded like a route. **POSSIBLE** *Somebody in the Empire has noticed the Sanctum is the building and not the presence.*

DEPARTED

FOCUSED STUDY F3 · ✣

EZEKIEL

A priest deported before the city fell, writing from a river in Babylonia about a God who left the building. Also the book that uses a woman's violated body as its central image of a nation's guilt, twice and at length.

WHY THIS IS A FOCUSED STUDY, FOR NOW

Nine pages hold the exile setting, the departing glory, the symbolic performances and the problem of chapters 16 and 23. If any of these becomes structural to TKC, the spread is promoted. It's the strongest promotion candidate in the queue.

CONTENT NOTE

Page 3 deals with sexual violence, public exposure as punishment and a woman's body used as a metaphor for national guilt. Skipping it is a legitimate choice. Skipping it without knowing isn't.

What it is

THE MAN	A priest, son of Buzi, among the deportees by the river Chebar in Babylonia. He isn't the only prophet of priestly family, since Jeremiah comes from the priests of Anathoth. What's distinctive is the combination, a priest whose whole recorded ministry happens in exile, away from the sanctuary he was trained to serve. It shapes everything the book does with temple, purity and space.
THE SETTING	Babylon takes Jerusalem's elite in stages. Ezekiel goes in an early wave, in 597 BCE, about a decade before the city and temple are destroyed. The first half of the book is a man warning an exile community about a catastrophe that hasn't happened yet, and that most of his hearers believe won't.
WHAT DEPORTATION WAS	Imperial policy and not a stampede: selective removal of a ruling class, craftsmen and royal family, resettlement in communities that kept some property and internal structure, and a client administration left behind. It was designed to take the head off a state while keeping it productive.
STRUCTURE	Chapters 1–24, judgment on Jerusalem before the fall. Chapters 25–32, oracles against the surrounding nations. Chapters 33–48, after the fall: restoration, the shepherds, the bones and a measured temple. The fall of the city is the hinge, and the book is built around it.
DATING SYSTEM	The book dates its oracles by years counted from King Jehoiachin's exile, and not by Babylonian regnal years. **INTERPRETATION** A community that dates its documents from the year its king was taken, and not from the reign of the power that took him, is choosing whose time it lives in.

> **DON'T REDUCE THE BOOK TO A MOBILE GOD**
>
> The departure of the glory from the temple is central and very useful for Dominion, and it isn't the whole book. Ezekiel is also about personal accountability, failed leadership, the ethics of prophetic speech and a detailed plan for rebuilding, and it ends with architecture more than travel.

EZEK 1.1–3

2 KGS 24–25

JER 1.1

EZEK 1–24

EZEK 33–48

GREENBERG, EZEKIEL

TKC: TL · DOM

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT AN EXILE COMMUNITY KEEPS, AND WHAT DOMINION WOULD TAKE FIRST

A PROPHET USED AS AN INSTRUMENT

Ezekiel mostly doesn't speak. He's made into a demonstration, positioned, restricted, silenced and bereaved so his body becomes the message. No other prophetic book does this on this scale.

THE CALL AND THE WHEELS · 1–3	A storm from the north, four living creatures with four faces each, wheels that move without turning with eyes on the rims, and above them the likeness of a throne with the likeness of a human form. The vocabulary is hedged at every turn, likeness, appearance, something like, because what he saw can't be reported plainly. He's handed a scroll and told to eat it, and it tastes like honey.
THE GLORY LEAVES · 8–11, RETURNS · 43	He's shown what's being done inside the temple, and the divine presence moves, from the inner sanctuary to the threshold, to the east gate, out of the city. It's a staged withdrawal, recorded like a route. Thirty-two chapters later it comes back by the same gate to a rebuilt house. INTERPRETATION The building was never the point. The presence was.
THE PERFORMANCES · 4–5, 12	He lies on one side and then the other for a counted number of days. He eats a measured siege ration. He shaves his head and beard and divides the hair. He digs through a wall and carries out a packed bag at dusk, like a refugee. Public, humiliating, sustained, and commissioned as prophecy.
THE DEATH OF HIS WIFE · 24.15–27	She's called the delight of his eyes. He's told in advance she'll die and told not to mourn her in public, no weeping and no rites, because his withheld grief is the sign of what's coming to the city. She dies, and he does as he was told. The text names her only by her relation to him, gives her no words and uses her death as an illustration. Whatever else the book is, it does that.

EZEK 1
EZEK 2–3
EZEK 4–5
EZEK 8–11
EZEK 12
EZEK 24.15–27
EZEK 43

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHAT THE EMPIRE WOULD DO WITH A LICENSED PROPHET WHOSE BODY IS THE BROADCAST

CONTENT NOTE Two extended prophetic allegories that describe women's bodies in explicit sexual terms and present stripping, public exposure, mutilation and killing as deserved punishment for infidelity. This page doesn't quote them. You can work it later, or not at all, and the spread still functions.

The metaphor that uses a woman's body

WHAT THEY ARE	Chapter 16 casts Jerusalem as a foundling who is raised, adorned, married and unfaithful. Chapter 23 casts Samaria and Jerusalem as two sisters whose political alliances are pictured as sexual pursuit of foreign soldiers.
THE ARGUMENT	Alliance with imperial powers is pictured as adultery, and the coming destruction as a husband's punishment of a wife, carried out by her former lovers with divine authorization. The violence is the argument.
WHY IT MATTERS	For centuries these chapters were preached with the gendered violence treated as decoration on a spiritual point. A large body of modern scholarship, feminist criticism in particular, argues the imagery can't be incidental and that its long use shapes how women hear divine judgment. It's serious scholarship and not a fringe complaint.
READINGS ON OFFER	**CONTESTED** The metaphor indicts a city and its leaders, and not women. It draws on treaty language, where infidelity is the standard charge. The shock is the intended effect. The imagery does harm whatever its intent. These can all be true together, and none of them makes the text safe.
THE COMPANION'S RULE	Name what the text does. Don't quote it to shock. Don't soften it into "unfaithfulness." Don't treat centuries of preaching on it as a neutral fact.

WHY THIS IS DIRECTLY TKC

POSSIBLE Dominion already measures a household's loyalty on a woman's body and stages exposure as correction. It has a scriptural warrant at length, in a major prophet. The question is whether it quotes these chapters in public or keeps them for the closed catechism.

EZEK 16

EZEK 23

HOS 1–3 (COMPARE)

WEEMS, BATTERED LOVE

GALAMBUSH, JERUSALEM IN THE BOOK OF EZEKIEL

TKC: DOM · MEN

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

MY OWN POSITION. WRITE IT DOWN ONCE, HERE, SO THE MANUSCRIPT STAYS CONSISTENT

AFTER THE CITY FALLS

EZEK 18
EXOD 20.5
LAM 5.7
EZEK 34
EZEK 37.1–14
EZEK 38–39
EZEK 40–48

WHOSE FAULT · 18	The chapter quotes a proverb the exiles are using, the parents have eaten sour grapes and the children's teeth are set on edge, and rejects it. The person who sins is the one who bears it, and someone who turns isn't held to their record. Read it against the commandment's language of punishment visited on later generations (Exod 20.5), against Lamentations' complaint that the children bear their parents' guilt (Lam 5.7), and against Ezekiel's own account of a whole city destroyed together. The Bible doesn't speak with one voice here, and the disagreement is the material.
THE SHEPHERDS · 34	An indictment of rulers who fed themselves on the flock, wore the wool, ate the fat, didn't strengthen the weak, heal the sick or search for the lost, and ruled with force. God removes them and takes the work personally, searching, gathering, feeding, binding up and judging between fat sheep and lean. The chapter then promises one shepherd, "my servant David." The office is emptied, worked directly and refilled on God's terms. **INTERPRETATION** It's the most quotable anti-leadership passage in the prophets and the hardest for an institution to circulate safely.
THE VALLEY OF DRY BONES · 37	He's set in a valley of bones and asked whether they can live, and he answers that God knows. The bones come together and breath enters them. The text interprets itself. The bones are the whole house of Israel, a people who believe they're finished. In context it's about national restoration. Later traditions read it as individual resurrection, and that reading has its own history. Keep the two apart.
GOG AND MAGOG · 38–39	A vast future invasion from the north, defeated. Later apocalyptic writing and modern political preaching have both mined these chapters for the enemy's identity. Note the pattern without adopting it, since naming a final enemy is a durable political technology.
THE MEASURED TEMPLE · 40–48	Nine chapters of specification: gates, courts, chambers, altar, priestly duties, festival calendar, a river flowing out of the sanctuary and a redivided land. A priest in exile answers catastrophe with a building plan and a rota. **CONTESTED** Whether it's a blueprint, a vision or a protest against the temple that failed. **INTERPRETATION** What it plainly is, is hope written as an ordinance.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

DOES DOMINION INHERIT GUILT BY HOUSEHOLD OR BY PERSON, AND DOES IT SAY THE SAME THING TWICE?

What I take out of Ezekiel

WRITING

SPREAD CLOSE

QUEUE: F3

THE DEPARTING PRESENCE. WHERE IT BELONGS IN THE FALL, AND WHO NOTICES IT LEAVING

A CHARACTER WHOSE BODY IS BEING USED AS SOMEONE ELSE'S MESSAGE

WHAT I STILL DON'T UNDERSTAND. CARRY IT TO THE RESEARCH LIST.

PROMOTION REVIEW *log only, no promotion is made here*

Ezekiel is a focused study with promotion available, and it's the likeliest promotion in the queue. Promote it if two or more of these hold: the departing glory becomes a structural motif more than an image, chapters 16 and 23 become part of the Empire's catechism on the page, the exile material feeds the Fall directly, or a character quotes the shepherds oracle.

DECISION | DATE | PAGES NEEDED

NOTES

OPEN NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DIDN'T FINISH

F7

COLLECTIVE FOCUSED STUDY

The Twelve

One scroll, twelve arguments, four centuries and three empires

SOURCE MARGIN

HOS–MAL

MT · LXX

NOGALSKI, THE BOOK OF THE TWELVE

SWEENEY, THE TWELVE PROPHETS

Register of the Twelve

ONE SCROLL, COUNTED AS ONE BOOK

HOSEA THROUGH MALACHI · ENTERED IN THE HEBREW ORDER

EIGHTH CENTURY	*Hosea · Amos · Micah · (Jonah, set here)*
SEVENTH CENTURY	*Nahum · Zephaniah · Habakkuk*
PERSIAN PERIOD	*Haggai · Zechariah · Malachi*
UNCERTAIN	*Joel · Obadiah*
EMPIRES ON THE HORIZON	*Assyria · Babylon · Persia*

The printed order isn't the order of writing. Read straight through, the Twelve gives you four centuries out of sequence. ***POSSIBLE*** *The Sanctum's lectionary doesn't mention this.*

OUT OF SEQUENCE

COLLECTIVE STUDY F7 · ✣

The Twelve

Twelve short books copied onto one scroll and counted as one. As a set they cover the rise and fall of two kingdoms under three empires, and no two of them make the same argument.

WHY COLLECTIVE, AND WHY NOW

Twelve separate dossiers would be out of proportion before you've read them. This study introduces the set, keeps each book's setting and argument intact, and leaves the promotions for you to decide.

CONTENT NOTES

Page 3 covers Hosea's marriage metaphor, with sexual accusation and violence against a wife. Page 5 covers a poem celebrating a city's destruction. Both are marked on the page.

One book or twelve

THE NAME	In Jewish tradition it's the Twelve, and one book. "Minor prophets" is a later Latin convention about length and not importance. If the word "minor" ever made you skip them, the convention was working.
ONE SCROLL	Twelve books of this size fit on one scroll, and ancient lists count them as one book. **CONTESTED** Whether they were also edited as one collection, with deliberate links across the seams, is an active scholarly argument.
THE ORDER VARIES	The Hebrew and Greek orders differ in the first six books. The sequence you're reading is a choice someone made, and any argument built on the arrangement depends on which arrangement.
OUT OF CHRONOLOGY	Amos and Hosea belong to the eighth century. Haggai, Zechariah and Malachi belong to the Persian period after the return.
DATING	Some books date themselves precisely by reign, some only by internal evidence, and three, Joel, Obadiah and Malachi, are genuinely uncertain. Don't print a date for those three as if it were given.

WHAT THE SET GIVES YOU THAT THE MAJOR PROPHETS DON'T

INTERPRETATION Twelve different answers to the same conditions. A prophet who says he isn't a professional prophet, a book that celebrates an empire's fall and a book furious that an empire was spared, a demand for justice and a demand for a building. As a set, the Twelve is the Bible arguing with itself in public.

WHICH OF THE TWELVE I COULD NAME BEFORE THIS PAGE, AND WHICH I COULDN'T

HOS 1.1

MAL 4.6

MT ORDER · LXX ORDER

NOGALSKI, BOOK OF THE TWELVE

SWEENEY, TWELVE PROPHETS

2 KGS 14–25

EZRA 1–6

SWEENEY, TWELVE PROPHETS

TKC: TL

Who was in power when

Prophecy is addressed to a situation. Without the empire on the horizon, every one of these books reads as general scolding. The placements below follow mainstream scholarship, and the three marked uncertain are genuinely open.

BOOK	SETTING	THE POWER IN THE ROOM
AMOS	Northern kingdom, 8th c.	Prosperity before Assyria arrives. A man from Judah speaking in the north.
HOSEA	Northern kingdom, 8th c.	Assyrian pressure and collapse inside. The north falls within his horizon.
MICAH	Judah, 8th c.	Assyrian campaigns. A voice from the countryside against the capital.
NAHUM	Judah, 7th c.	Assyria's capital about to fall, or just fallen.
ZEPHANIAH	Judah, 7th c.	Late Assyrian period. Addressed to Jerusalem's officials and merchants.
HABAKKUK	Judah, late 7th c.	Babylon rising and named as the instrument.
HAGGAI	Judah, Persian period	Dated to the month under a Persian king. Temple rebuilding.
ZECHARIAH	Judah, Persian period	The same moment as Haggai in chapters 1–8. Chapters 9–14 are widely held to be later.
JONAH	Set in the Assyrian era	Set then. Generally thought to be written considerably later, looking back.
JOEL	Uncertain	No king named. Placements range widely. Say "uncertain" and mean it.
OBADIAH	Uncertain	Most often tied to the aftermath of Jerusalem's fall, on internal evidence.
MALACHI	Persian period	A working temple with slack practice. No king named, and the title may be a role ("my messenger") more than a name.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH ERA MY EMPIRE IS IN. RISING, PEAKING, OR BEING NAMED AS THE INSTRUMENT

HOS 1–3

JOEL 2.28–29

ACTS 2.16–21

AMOS 2.6–8

AMOS 7.10–17

WEEMS, BATTERED LOVE

SWEENEY, TWELVE PROPHETS

Hosea · Joel · Amos

CONTENT NOTE The Hosea entry concerns a marriage metaphor built on sexual accusation, public exposure and violence against a wife. It doesn't quote the imagery.

HOSEA · NORTH, 8TH C.	A prophet told to marry, and three children whose names are the message: Jezreel, a place of slaughter, Lo-ruhamah, "not pitied," and Lo-ammi, "not my people." The book runs the nation's covenant failure through a wife accused of infidelity, with stripping, drought and public shaming as the announced punishment, beside some of the tenderest reconciliation language in scripture. **Study:** the marriage metaphor, Gomer as a person and as a device, the children's names, sexual accusation, gendered violence, and the reversal of the names at the end.
JOEL · SETTING UNCERTAIN	A locust invasion described in military language, a call to communal lament, and a promise of restoration and of the spirit poured out on the whole community. No king is named and no empire identified, which is why the book won't date. The outpouring names sons and daughters, old and young, and a third group translations render as household servants or as enslaved men and women. Check three translations and a lexicon before quoting, because the social claim changes with the choice. **Study:** the locusts, the Day of the LORD, lament as procedure, and Peter's reuse of the passage in Acts 2.
AMOS · SPEAKS IN THE NORTH, 8TH C.	Oracles against the surrounding nations circle inward until they land on Israel. After that comes a sustained attack on the sale of the poor, the seizure of garments and grain, and worship offered by the people doing it. Confronted at the royal sanctuary by the priest Amaziah and told to go home, he answers that he's a herdsman and a dresser of sycamore figs and that God took him from the flock. **CONTESTED** Whether he's denying any connection to the professional prophets, or only that he was trained among them. He's also from Judah speaking in the north, which is a problem of jurisdiction as much as class. **Study:** the nations sequence, the sale of persons for debt, ivory beds, rejected worship, Amaziah, the plumb line and the basket of summer fruit.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old companion called Amos "a farmer from the wrong kingdom." He calls himself a herdsman and a worker of sycamore figs, livestock and orchard work, possibly a man of some means. It also said Hosea's God "keeps taking the nation back," which is true of the reconciliation passages and silent about the violence that comes first.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHICH OF THESE THREE I WANT IN THE MANUSCRIPT, AND IN WHOSE MOUTH

OBAD 10–14

PS 137 (COMPARE)

JONAH 4

2 KGS 14.25

MIC 2.1–2

MIC 3.5–11

MIC 6.8

RAABE, OBADIAH (AB)

Obadiah · Jonah · Micah

OBADIAH · UNCERTAIN · SHORTEST BOOK	One chapter against Edom, a neighboring people condemned for what it did on the day Jerusalem fell: standing aloof, gloating over the disaster, entering the gate and joining the plunder, cutting off fugitives at the crossroads and handing over survivors. Edom isn't shown leading the invasion. It's charged with every item on that list. **Study:** Edom in the family stories and the prophets, bystanding as a named offense, profit from a neighbor's catastrophe, and what the shortest book in the Bible chooses to spend its one chapter on.
JONAH · SET IN THE ASSYRIAN ERA	A prophet gets a commission and sails the other way. A storm, sailors who behave better than he does, the fish, a sermon of five Hebrew words, a mass repentance that includes the livestock, and a prophet furious that it worked. It ends on a question about mercy that's never answered. CONTESTED "Satire" is one major classification and a useful one. Parable, teaching novella and prophetic legend are held seriously too. **Study:** mercy for an enemy empire, nationalism, prophetic refusal, Nineveh as a real capital and a symbol, repentance from the throne down, and the plant, the worm and the unanswered question.
MICAH · JUDAH, 8TH C.	Judgment on both capitals, with a specific economic charge against people who lie awake planning how to take fields and houses, and take them, because they have the power. Rulers who hate justice, judges who take bribes, priests who teach for a price and prophets who cry peace as long as they're fed. In the same book, a ruler from a small town, and the famous line about what's required. **Study:** land seizure, prophets for hire, the threat against Zion, Bethlehem, and the courtroom framing of chapter 6.

MICAH ISN'T ONE VERSE

INTERPRETATION Reading only 6.8 removes the land seizure, the bought clergy, the threat against the capital, and the fact that the verse answers a question about what an offering can buy. Study the argument it concludes.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

A PROPHET WHO IS ANGRY THAT MERCY WAS EXTENDED. DOES DOMINION HAVE ONE?

NAH 3.1–7

HAB 1–2.5

HAB 3

ZEPH 1.7–13

ZEPH 3.11–13

SWEENEY, TWELVE PROPHETS

Nahum · Habakkuk · Zephaniah

CONTENT NOTE The Nahum entry concerns a poem that celebrates a city's destruction and uses sexualized humiliation of a personified capital as part of the celebration. It doesn't quote the imagery.

NAHUM · JUDAH, 7TH C.	Three chapters on the fall of Assyria's capital in fast, visual poetry, chariots in the streets, the crack of the whip, bodies heaped up, and a taunt addressed to the city as a woman to be exposed before the nations. **Hold both:** Calling it a provincial revenge song dismisses where it's written from. Assyria deported whole populations, flayed captives and advertised it, and this is the voice of people who were on the receiving end of a terror state watching it end. It's also not innocent. The gendered humiliation is doing real work, and the book's pleasure in the violence isn't incidental. **Study:** Assyrian imperial practice, the poetry of a city's fall, who's allowed to celebrate, and the opening hymn about patience and wrath.
HABAKKUK · JUDAH, LATE 7TH C.	Built as an argument. The prophet complains that violence goes unanswered. The reply names Babylon as the instrument. The prophet objects that this is worse. The second reply is a set of woes against the plunderer, a line about the righteous living by faithfulness, and an order to write the vision down plainly and wait. It closes with a psalm that chooses trust without claiming anything has improved. **Study:** complaint as a legitimate prophetic form, God's use of an empire, faith or faithfulness and its later reuse, and waiting.
ZEPHANIAH · JUDAH, 7TH C.	A Day of the LORD announced as near, dark and total, and aimed with unusual precision at officials, the king's sons, traders and people grown so comfortable they assume nothing will happen. A remnant is left, described as humble, people who won't do wrong and won't be afraid. **Study:** the Day of the LORD across the Twelve, the ruling class as named target, complacency as an offense, and who the remnant consists of.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old companion said Habakkuk got "an unsatisfying answer." The phrase is a verdict and not a description. The reply doesn't answer the question asked, and the book knows it, which is why it ends in waiting.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

WHO IN MY WORLD IS ALLOWED TO CELEBRATE THE FALL, AND WHO IS TOLD IT'S UNSEEMLY

HAG 1.2–11

EZRA 5.1–2

ZECH 1–6

ZECH 3

ZECH 9.9

MAL 2.10–16

MAL 3.1

MAL 4.5–6

HUGENBERGER, MARRIAGE AS A COVENANT

Haggai · Zechariah · Malachi

HAGGAI · PERSIAN PERIOD, DATED PRECISELY	Four dated messages in a few months, all on one subject. The temple is a ruin while people live in finished, paneled houses. The economics are blunt. You sow much and harvest little, you earn wages to put in a bag with holes, and the shortfall is blamed on the unbuilt house. The work restarts, and Ezra names Haggai and Zechariah as the prophets who got it moving. **Study:** rebuilding under imperial authorization, scarcity and its explanation, the governor and the high priest, and what religious construction costs ordinary households.
ZECHARIAH · PERSIAN PERIOD, AND LATER MATERIAL	Eight night visions with a messenger who interprets them, horses and riders, a measuring line, a lampstand, a flying scroll, chariots, and a courtroom where the high priest stands in filthy clothes, is accused and is dressed again. Later oracles include a king riding on a donkey and a shepherd sequence the gospel writers draw on heavily. **Study:** how symbolic vision works, the priesthood restored by new clothes, the two olive trees, the donkey-riding king, the pierced one and the struck shepherd, and the gospels' reuse of them, read as reuse.
MALACHI · PERSIAN PERIOD	Built as a run of disputes. A claim is made, the audience objects and the objection is answered. The targets are priests offering blemished animals, men who've dealt treacherously with the wives of their youth (a passage on divorce with real textual difficulty), people withholding what's owed, and a general feeling that serving God isn't worth it. It promises a messenger who will refine the priesthood and closes with Elijah, turning the hearts of parents and children to each other.

CORRECTION TO THE OLD COMPANION The old companion said the last word of the Old Testament is an accusation against clergy. The claim only works in the Christian order, since Chronicles comes last in the Jewish one, and even there Malachi's closing verses are about Elijah and families. The claim is dropped.

A PROPHET WHOSE MESSAGE IS "FINISH THE BUILDING." WHOSE INTERESTS DOES THAT SERVE?

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

A PROPHET WHOSE MESSAGE IS "FINISH THE BUILDING." WHOSE INTERESTS DOES THAT SERVE?

MIC 3.5–8

AMOS 5.21–24

HAG 1.4–6

MAL 3.8–10

HAB 2.6–17

TKC: DOM

Which prophets an empire keeps

INTERPRETATION The Twelve holds both kinds, prophets who tell an institution to finish its building and prophets who tell it its worship is worthless while it sells the poor. Any empire that licenses a prophetic office is choosing from exactly this range, and the choice is the doctrine.

WHAT THE SANCTUM CIRCULATES	WHAT IT KEEPS IN THE CLOSED CATECHISM
HAGGAI. FINISH THE HOUSE, AND THE SHORTFALL IS YOUR FAULT FOR NOT FINISHING IT.	Micah. The people who lie awake planning how to take fields, and take them, because they can.
MALACHI. BRING THE FULL TITHE INTO THE STOREHOUSE.	Malachi. The priests are the first ones charged.
HOSEA'S RECONCILIATION. THE GOD WHO TAKES HER BACK.	Hosea's mechanism. The exposure and shaming that come before the taking back.
ZEPHANIAH'S REMNANT. THE HUMBLE WHO ARE SPARED.	Zephaniah's target list. Officials, the king's sons and the merchants.
NAHUM. THE ENEMY EMPIRE FALLS, BECAUSE WE'RE THE RIGHTEOUS ONES.	Habakkuk. The empire God is using is judged for the same violence.
AMOS'S CLOSING RESTORATION VERSES.	Everything in Amos before them, and the priest of the royal sanctuary telling him to leave the country.

THE TEST THE TWELVE ACTUALLY OFFERS

INTERPRETATION Micah names prophets who cry peace while they're being fed and declare war on anyone who stops feeding them. Applied, that gives a working test more than a moral one. Follow the money and see whose interest the message serves. It works on the Sanctum and on anyone the characters are inclined to trust. It's an interpretive use of Micah, and the text doesn't prescribe it.

WRITING

FROM THE FACING PAGE

THE SANCTUM'S APPROVED PROPHETIC CANON. LIST WHAT'S IN AND WHAT'S SEALED

WRITING

HOS–MAL

TKC: DOM · TL

Build the prophetic office

Six pages of reference have given you twelve models. This page turns them into Dominion's institution.

1 · HOW A PERSON BECOMES A LICENSED PROPHET IN DOMINION, AND WHO REVOKES IT

2 · AN UNLICENSED VOICE WHO IS RIGHT. WHAT HAPPENS AT THE SANCTUARY DOOR

3 · THE EMPIRE'S OWN "DAY OF THE LORD." WHAT IT PROMISES AND WHOM IT THREATENS

4 · ONE ORACLE, IN FULL, IN THE SANCTUM'S VOICE. THE SAME EVENT FROM OUTSIDE IT

Which of the Twelve earns more study

The audit names seven as likely to need their own focused study later: Hosea, Amos, Jonah, Micah, Habakkuk, Zechariah and Malachi. Read this collective study before deciding. The audit column records its seven, and the mark column is yours. Nothing is promoted from this page.

BOOK	AUDIT	MARK	WHY, IN ONE LINE
Hosea	AUDIT		
Joel			
Amos	AUDIT		
Obadiah			
Jonah	AUDIT		
Micah	AUDIT		
Nahum			
Habakkuk	AUDIT		
Zephaniah			
Haggai			
Zechariah	AUDIT		
Malachi	AUDIT		

WRITING

SPREAD
CLOSE

QUEUE: F7

What I take out of the Twelve

THE ONE BOOK OF THE TWELVE THAT CHANGED HOW I SEE THE EMPIRE

WHAT I STILL DON'T UNDERSTAND. CARRY IT TO THE RESEARCH LIST.

PROMOTION REVIEW *log only, no promotion is made here*

BOOKS MARKED | DATE | TIER PROPOSED

NOTES

OPEN NOTES

ANYTHING THIS STUDY STARTED AND DIDN'T FINISH

NOTES

ANYTHING THIS SPREAD STARTED AND DID NOT FINISH